Russian intervention and Trump’s election reset the Iranian chessboard

As noted earlier, a visit by Chinese warships to Bandar Abbas in September 2014 signalled Beijing’s willingness to develop military ties with Iran. But massive Russian intervention in the Syrian civil war starting in September 2015 meant that Russia, not China, would emerge as Iran’s main military partner. This did not particularly increase the convergence of Chinese and Indian interests regarding Iran, but given India’s traditional good ties and understanding with Russia, the abrupt emergence of this Russian–Iranian entente did alleviate Indian concerns that China might develop a genuine strategic partnership with Iran. A Sino–Iranian entente would severely diminish India’s security. A Russo–Iranian entente would create difficulties for the smooth development of India–US ties but would not, in itself, diminish Indian security. A burgeoning Sino–Iranian strategic partnership would produce vigorous Indian counter-action; a Russian–Iranian entente would be far less disturbing to New Delhi. Russo–Iranian entente could also benefit India by acting as a prophylactic excluding Beijing. Russo–Iranian entente could also facilitate the North–South Transit Corridor and the Chabahar project, with Indian involvement in both of those projects.

In September 2015, the Syrian government of Bashar al-Assad formally requested Russian military assistance in the Syrian civil war. Tehran was Assad’s major foreign backer, and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps was in the process of bringing to bear in Syria IRGC-controlled Shi’ite militia forces from Lebanon, Iraq, and Afghanistan. Combining IRGC-controlled ground forces with Russian advisors, air power, and naval bombardment from Russian warships in the Caspian Sea and eastern Mediterranean, plus special operations forces, radically altered the battlefield in